

WASTED CHARITY

Crores of rupees of foreign donations have gone down the drain as the NRI-funded charitable hospitals in rural Punjab either call in sick or fail to take off

■ **By Ramesh Vinayak**

In the early 1990s, the panchayat of Kala Sanghian village of Punjab's Kapurthala district mooted the idea of setting up a 100-bed charitable hospital in the name of a locally-revered saint, Baba Kahan Dass. Its foreign-settled natives responded enthusiastically, sending a deluge of donations. It took 13 years and Rs 4 crore to complete the hospital building in 2003. Yet, four years later, the double-storey marble-floored structure resembles anything but a hospital. Ironically, the only sign of it being one is a faded red cross painted on its facade.

While the front courtyard serves as

a cattle shed, sacks of wheat and a make-shift flour machine jostle for space in the dust-laden, cobweb-infested ground floor which was earmarked as the outpatient department (OPD) but is now the store for the community kitchen of an adjacent gurdwara. The 'Emergency Room' is stacked with a bevy of large *langar* utensils; and the patient wards with iron beds serve as accommodation for *granthis*. Mired in vicious litigation over its management, the hospital was never commissioned. "The novel project has fallen victim to local rivalries," rues village sarpanch Narinder Singh.

Kala Sanghian is not an exception but a stark example of NRI-funded hos-

pitals going bust in the countryside in Punjab. Nowhere is the wasted charity more evident than in the dollar-rich Doaba region—Jalandhar, Kapurthala, Hoshiarpur and Nawanshahar districts and home to roughly two million expatriates—where NRI donations have established an impressive health infrastructure that the best government hospitals in urban areas can't dream of.

In the past decade-and-a-half, 40-odd charitable hospitals have been built in Punjab with NRI funds of about Rs 800 crore—roughly equal to the state's annual health budget. Most of these projects, with costs ranging from Rs 2 crore to Rs 80 crore, are named after Sikh gurus or native saints—a factor that strikes an emotional chord for charity among expatriates and tacitly helps the local religious sect chiefs (babas) to expand their clout.

▼ **HOSPITAL:** Guru Nanak Nirmal Charitable Hospital **Started by** Nirmal Kutia dera head Sant Moniji in 1998.

LOCATION: PANDAVA VILLAGE, NEAR PHAGWARA

MONEY SPENT: Rs 8 crore

STATUS: Project abandoned 7 years ago

WHO'S TO BLAME: Split in the managing committee after the baba died

